

Untitled - April 17, 2026

Speaker In eighteen twenty one, um, the government of the Netherlands had this really mundane problem. They basically needed to, you know, clear out some storage space, right? A classic administrative headache. Exactly. So some mid-level bureaucrats looked at the massive centuries old archives of the Dutch East and West India companies. I mean, millions upon millions of pages of colonial records, which are literally the foundational documents of a global empire. Yeah. And they made a decision. They didn't, uh, meticulously index them. They didn't move them to a safer vault. They literally sold them to a pulp mill. Oh, it's just agonizing to even think about. It really is. Eighty zero zero zero pounds of irreplaceable historical records were just shoveled into an industrial grinder, completely destroyed and recycled into blank scrap paper. Wow. And with the stroke of a pen, the actual documented history of the founding of New York City was just wiped off the face of the earth. Yeah. It remains, I mean, one of the most staggering, agonizing acts of bureaucratic vandalism in modern history, because what rushed in to fill that massive historical void wasn't the truth. It was, well, a ghost story, a complete fabrication, right? A complete fabrication that would eventually morph into the greatest, most unshakable real estate myth ever told. Which is exactly why we are plunging into this deep dive today. And we are talking directly to you, our listener. That's right. Because you are a video creator and you are staring down a pretty massive, ambitious project. Yeah. You want to make an engaging, long form video essay about the myth of the Manhattan Purchase. You want to dodge the tired cliches, avoid the textbook summaries, and, you know, uncover the actual history behind America's most famous, most misunderstood transaction. And most importantly, you want to build your entire narrative exclusively on primary sources. Yes, it is a phenomenal topic for your video, but it requires a very specific architecture. So the mission today is to hand you that framework. We're basically going to walk through a completely counterintuitive narrative structure that you can take straight to your editing bay. Exactly. To do that, we have pulled together a really fascinating stack of materials. We're looking at seventeenth century Dutch West India Company records, the famous sixteen twenty six letter from Peter Sagan, notes on nineteenth century historical paintings and all those agonizing accounts of the lost archives. Right. Plus the very latest modern museum curation notes. Looking ahead to the twenty twenty six four hundredth anniversary of New York. So the story you need to tell your audience here is essentially an investigation. Yeah. Do not start your video with the twenty four dollars. And definitely do not start with the beads and the trinkets, right? You want to start at exactly like a true crime documentary where the murder weapon is completely missing. Yeah. Tell your viewers that everything they think they know about this foundational event is a hallucination, because the document that's supposedly birthed the financial capital of the world just doesn't exist. and in its place is a fascinating trail of clues. That framing creates immediate, gripping tension for a viewer. You're hooking them by completely destabilizing their preconceived notions. And once you've torn down the myth in like the first 30s of your video, their immediate question is going to be, okay, then what actually happened in sixteen twenty six? Exactly. Which transitions us perfectly into the first major section of your narrative. Let's look at what we'll call the birth certificate and the cargo manifest. Right. Because if you're promising your audience a story built on primary sources. Well, you have to start with the only piece of paper that actually survives from the year of the

event itself. Yes. Sixteen twenty six. It's the year every single New York school child is taught to memorize. But what actually survives from that specific year regarding this monumental transaction is shockingly, almost comically brief. It really is. It is a single letter written by a man named Peter Sagan dated November fifth, sixteen twenty six. Now, when you are visualizing this part of your script, your instinct might be to show some grand painting or a dramatic reenactment. Don't do that. No. Absolutely not. You want to ground the viewer in the reality of the paper. Focus on the text of this letter. Because when you actually read it, you realize immediately that it is not a treaty. It's not a legal deed. It's just a mundane corporate status report. To understand the tone of this document, you really have to understand who is writing it. Peter Sagan wasn't a poet and he wasn't an explorer, right? He was a representative of the States general in the Assembly of the nineteen, basically the board of directors for the Dutch West India Company. He was sitting in a comfortable room in Amsterdam, writing a routine update about the arrival of a ship called the Arms of Amsterdam, a ship which had just sailed back across the Atlantic from their colony of New Netherland. Exactly. And the actual mention of the purchase of Manhattan is completely buried. It's almost an afterthought. Yeah, it is literally a single sentence sandwich between an update on the local farming conditions and a massive inventory of dead animals. I'm going to read the exact literal translation so you can hear how dry it is. Go for it. Shogun writes they have purchased the island Manhattan from the Indians for the value of sixty guilders. It is eleven thousand Morgens in size. That is it. That one sentence is the entire comprehensive contemporary record of the transaction. Everything we definitively know from sixteen twenty six fits into those twenty two words. It's completely absurd. I mean, it's like finding the foundational birth certificate for the most valuable, iconic real estate in the world. Scribbles in the margins of a grocery receipt. Yeah, it really is. Because right after he drops that bomb about buying Manhattan, Shogun just moves on. He casually starts listing the agricultural samples the ship brought back like wheat, rye, barley, oats, buckwheat, canary seed beans, and flax. And then he gets to the real point of the letter. The reason the ship was actually sent the cargo manifest, right. He meticulously lists seven thousand two hundred and forty six beaver skins. He lists one hundred and seventy eight and a half otter skins, plus mink skins, wildcat skins and muskrat skins. Okay, wait, I have to pause on that. Seven thousand two hundred and forty six Beaver Skins. That specific number is such a crucial detail for your video, because it completely shatters the modern romanticization of early New York. Oh, absolutely. The Dutch were not arriving with some grand philosophical vision of building a shining metropolis on a hill. No, they were running a corporate extraction machine. That is the essential context. The Dutch West India Company was a massive, aggressive, profit driven commercial enterprise. Their primary overwhelming motivation in the early years of New Netherland was the global fur trade. Because beaver pelts were incredibly lucrative in Europe at the time, extremely lucrative. They were used to make felt hats, which were a massive status symbol, and the European beaver population had been virtually hunted to extinction. So the purchase of Manhattan wasn't a real estate development project in their minds. It was a strategic business decision precisely to secure a defensible deep water port to protect their fur extraction operation from the English and the French. So when we look back at that one sentence, they have purchased the island man hats from the Indians for the value sixty guilders. We have to notice what is glaringly missing, right? There's no mention of twenty four dollars. There's no mention of beads. There's no mention of trinkets. There are no names

of the Native American sellers. It is just a flat, bloodless corporate accounting line. And what we really need to examine is that specific figure sixty guilders, because your viewers are inherently going to ask the question, well, why sixty guilders? Did that actually mean anything at the time? Was it a complete rip off even by seventeenth century standards? Right. Because sixty guilders sounds like nothing. So what does that actually represent to a person living in sixteen twenty six. Well, to understand the value, we have to strip away centuries of historical mockery and look at it through the economic reality of the seventeenth century. Okay? At that time, a common soldier working for the Dutch West India Company, like a man putting his life on the line in a frontier colony, earned about one hundred guilders for an entire year of labor. Oh, wow. Okay, that reframes things completely. So sixty guilders wasn't the equivalent of, you know, the spare change you find in your couch cushions. It was well over half a year's wages for a working class European man. Precisely. It was a substantial, meaningful sum of value. Furthermore, we have to look closely at the phrasing. It says for the value of sixty guilders, they did not hand over a sack of metal coins because metal currency was scarce and virtually useless in the North American wilderness anyway. Exactly. They exchanged physical trade goods that added up to sixty guilders on the Dutch company's ledger. What kind of goods are we talking about here? Well, the Shogun letter doesn't list them. We know from countless other Dutch West India Company records of the era what these trade goods consisted of. They were highly utilitarian items like what iron kettles, metal axes, awls, knives, duffel cloth. These were items that held immense practical utility and transformative value for the Native Americans. So your video really needs to hammer this point home to the people standing there in sixteen twenty six. This was not a joke. It was a serious, heavily capitalized transaction. Yes. Very serious. And from the European perspective, land in a completely undeveloped wilderness state was considered practically dirt cheap anyway. They were paying for the right to establish a fortified trading post, not buying a city grid with skyscrapers. Right. And if we pull back and look at the bigger picture, this single sentence in the Shogun letter serves one vital, undeniable purpose. It proves that a transaction took place right. It proves the Dutch believed internally that they had executed a legal purchase according to their own strict corporate protocols. Exactly. But and this is where your video's narrative takes a massive turn. That one sentence gives us absolutely zero mechanical details about the deal itself, which sets up a screaming mystery for your audience. Well, absolutely. Because if your viewers are following the logic, they're going to say, okay, the Dutch were a massive bureaucratic corporation. They clearly kept receipts. So where is the actual contract? Where is the deed? And that very logical question is what propels your narrative directly into the void? This is where you reveal the tragedy of eighteen twenty one. Yeah. As historian Robert Grummitt explicitly points out in the sources we're looking at, there is no deed. There is no bill of sale chronicling the purchase of Manhattan. The paper simply does not exist. And the reason it doesn't exist is what makes this story so uniquely painful. It wasn't a dramatic disaster. The archives didn't go down in a romantic shipwreck in a storm across the Atlantic. Right. They didn't burn in a tragic, heroic fire during a war. No. They were destroyed by pure, unadulterated bureaucratic banality. This is where you lean heavily back into that investigative tone. You need to explain the mechanics of what the Dutch government actually did. So in eighteen twenty one, the government of the Netherlands was undergoing a phase of administrative consolidation. They looked at the massive repositories of the defunct Dutch East and West India companies. These were

millions of pages of colonial records from before the year seventeen hundred. Yeah. The bureaucrats simply decided that these dusty old corporate papers were taking up too much valuable real estate in their warehouses, so they didn't even try to sell them to a university or a private collector. They literally sold them by the pound to a pulp mill to be ground down into mush and turned into blank paper. That's exactly what happened. Eighty thousand pounds of history gone for your video. This is such a powerful narrative moment. Mhm. Imagine explaining to your viewers the sheer scale of that loss. Imagine massive piles of seventeenth century parchment deeds with thick wax seals, intimate letters written by colonial directors like Peter Minuit and Willem Verhulst, maps of untouched coastlines, all of it, yeah, all being casually tossed into a nineteenth century industrial grinder. It is a devastating reality, and we know exactly how devastating it was because of the reaction of a man named John Romeyn Brodhead in eighteen thirty nine, eighteen years after this massive archival purge, Brodhead traveled to The Hague. Okay, so he's looking for these documents, right? He was acting as an agent for the state of New York, and he was on a specific, highly funded mission to find the foundational documents of the original Dutch colony. So he crosses the Atlantic, he walks into the archives, and what happens? He discovers the absolute void. He is told what happened in eighteen twenty one. Brodhead later wrote that he was met with overwhelming surprise, mortification and regret when he realized the scale of the destruction because the very papers he had crossed an ocean to find the foundational texts of his home state had been recycled into scrap paper nearly two decades prior. Exactly. So let's unpack the consequence of this void for your video. Why does this missing paperwork matter so much to the story of New York? Because it created a vacuum. We know beyond a shadow of a doubt. From surviving instructions given to early colonial directors, that the West India Company operated with heavy, strict, incredibly dense administrative protocols. They were lawyers and accountants at heart. Exactly. They didn't just hand over a pile of axes and wave goodbye. They drafted extensive multi-page contracts. They surveyed the land. They legally recorded the names and titles of the indigenous sellers. The original deed for Manhattan almost certainly existed, and it was almost certainly a highly detailed legal document. But because it was pulped, the event was violently stripped of all its specific factual contours. We lost the names of the Native American leaders who were present. We lost the itemized list of the actual trade goods that made up those sixty guilders. We lost the exact date of the signing. We lost the geographic boundaries of what the Native Americans actually thought they were agreeing to. And as the old saying goes, nature abhors a vacuum. History of horrors of vacuum. Even more, when you have an event as globally significant as the founding of New York City, and the actual documentation is completely wiped off the face of the earth. Well, human beings are not just going to leave that space blank. No, they are going to fill that void with their own stories. Which brings us to the most mind blowing part of this entire deep dive, and the core of what you need to explain to your audience next. The invention of the myth. Yes, because if the seventeenth century records were utterly destroyed, where on earth did we get the ultra specific number of twenty four dollars? And where did the powerful, ubiquitous imagery of beads and trinkets come from? This is the pivot point of your narrative. You are shifting from a story about historical loss to a story about active historical invention. Because these elements, the twenty four dollars and the beads were not handed down through generations of careful oral history. No, not at all. They were completely fabricated out of whole cloth in the mid nineteenth century. Let's tackle the

twenty four dollars first. I want your viewers to realize how incredibly precise this origin point is. You can trace the exact moment the twenty four dollars myth was born. It didn't happen in the sixteen hundreds. It happened in January of eighteen forty four. Yes. The architect of this number was a budding historian and writer named Edmund Bailey O'Callaghan. In eighteen forty four, he was writing a piece for an Albany, New York journal called The Northern Light. Okay. And O'Callaghan had recently come across a translation of that brief Peter Sagan letter, the one we discussed earlier with the sixty guilders, right, the cargo manifest. So O'Callaghan looks at the phrase sixty guilders, and he decides, simply for the benefit of his eighteen forty four American readership, to do a direct mathematical currency conversion into eighteen forty four US dollars. Wait, I have to make sure I understand the mechanics of this. He literally just looked up the exchange rate of a seventeenth century Dutch guilder against a nineteenth century American dollar. Exactly. It was a purely mathematical exercise, completely stripped of any historical, social or economic context. He didn't factor in purchasing power parity. He didn't factor in the inflation of two centuries, and he certainly didn't factor in the relative value of sixty guilders to a seventeenth century laborer. Not at all. He just did the raw math and calculated that sixty guilders equaled exactly twenty four U.S. dollars in eighteen forty four. So he publishes his article and writes the purchase of the island of Manhattan for the sum of sixty dollars or twenty four dollars. And boom, just like that, a virus injected into the historical record. It's so arbitrary. I mean, it's like taking a medieval document that says a king bought a castle for one thousand gold florins. Typing it into a modern internet inflation calculator and writing a textbook that says the castle was bought for exactly fourteen thousand three hundred and twenty two dollars. Right. It's completely missing the point. It completely obliterates what that value actually meant to the people living through it. It is a profound historical anachronism, but you have to understand why it caught on. It was an incredibly catchy, deeply ironic number. O'Callaghan himself referred to it in print as a trifling sum. Yeah. The idea that the entirety of Manhattan, which by the eighteen forties was already becoming a massive, booming metropolis, was bought for a mere twenty four dollars, was just too delicious for nineteenth century readers to resist. Oh, they loved it. It spread like wildfire in newspapers across the country. It was the perfect, punchy piece of trivia for the rising Penny press. Okay, so that perfectly explains the price tag. But what about the beads? Because when you close your eyes right now and picture the purchase of Manhattan, you don't picture iron axes and awls. You picture an open wooden chest spilling over with brightly colored glass beads and cheap trinkets. Right. So where did that specific visual come from if not from a text? This is where the story gets really fascinating, and it's a brilliant visual for a video essay. The imagery of the beads didn't come from a historian's pen. It came from a painter's brush. You absolutely have to show this artwork in your video. So the year is eighteen fifty three. A prominent painter named William Rainey completes a scene titled Purchase of Manhattan. And in this painting, right in the dead center of the composition, is a Dutch colonist holding out a long, brightly colored string of beads to a Native American leader. Wow. It is the very first time we see this specific visual associated with the Manhattan Purchase. But Randy didn't have a time machine. He didn't have access to the West India Company archives because they had been pulped thirty years earlier. So what was his source material? Why did he choose to paint beads? Because he borrowed the visual from another, much more famous painting. At that time, the absolute most celebrated, iconic artistic depiction of colonial land deals was Benjamin

West's seventeen seventy one painting of William Penn's Treaty with the Indians in Pennsylvania. Okay West's painting famously featured a prominent open chest of trade goods, including what looked very much like beads and cloth being offered in a serene, peaceful exchange. Oh, that is wild. So Randy essentially copy pasted the aesthetic vibe of William Penn's Treaty and just grafted it onto the Dutch in New York. Precisely. Randy was trying to give New York a founding image that was just as noble, just as peaceful, and just as mutually agreeable as Pennsylvania's famous origin story. And this visual was incredibly sticky. Once Randy painted the beads, the image became reality in the minds of the public. Yeah, it stuck permanently. Decades later, in eighteen seventy five, a highly influential historian named Martha Lamb wrote a massive, definitive history of New York City. She looked to the prevailing cultural imagery, and she explicitly wrote into her text that the Dutch gave the Indians beads, buttons, and other trinkets. Right. She took Randy's purely visual invention and codified it backward into the textual history in the ultimate unshakable cementing of this myth happens in nineteen oh nine. This is a crucial event to include in your video the Hudson-fulton celebration. Oh yes, it was a massive, unprecedented two week long party in New York celebrating the three hundredth anniversary of Henry Hudson's voyage. They threw a gigantic parade down Fifth Avenue with over a million spectators lining the streets, and what was rolling down the street in front of all those people. I can only imagine. The fifteenth float in that parade was officially titled The Purchase of Manhattan. It was a gargantuan papier mache display showing oversized Dutchmen actively handing out shiny trinkets to Native Americans. I'm unbelievable at that exact moment, with a million people cheering. The myth of the twenty four dollars and the beads became permanent, institutionalized American folklore. Let me push back on this a little bit. Or rather, let's dig into the psychology here. Why did nineteenth century New Yorkers want this myth so badly? That's a great question. Why did the elites, the historical society, the wealthy descendants of the early colonists, why did they need to believe the Dutch bought Manhattan for twenty four dollars in beads? That raises a really vital point about historiography that your video can explore. You have to look at the psychological and political needs of nineteenth century New York. By the eighteen forties and eighteen fifties, New York was aggressively emerging as a global economic powerhouse. The elites of the city, the newly minted millionaires, wanted an origin story that could be intensely proud of. Right. They didn't want an origin story rooted in violent conquest, bloody theft, or moral ambiguity. Exactly. They looked at other colonial powers, like the Spanish and South America, with their brutal conquests, or the violent early English settlements, and they saw narratives of brute force. The New York elites desperately wanted to believe that their city, the glittering capital of American commerce, was uniquely founded on a fair, legal, honest business deal. It's the ultimate capitalist comfort blanket. Like, we didn't steal this land. We bought it fair and square. We executed a contract. As the historian Richard Howe points out in our source materials, this myth served as an imperialism of a more sophisticated sort by insisting on the framework of a European style real estate transaction, they impose their own Western legal identity onto the Native Americans. Wasn't simple deceit. It was a psychological mechanism to make the taking of Manhattan feel entirely legal, justified, and morally clean under Western law. And how makes a really incredible point about why this matters so much today. He says that the Manhattan Purchase is the primal real estate transaction. Every single property title in Manhattan today, from a tiny studio apartment in Greenwich Village to the sprawling footprint of

the Empire State Building. Yeah, all of it ultimately descends legally from this one undocumented, completely mythologized sixteen twenty six transaction. That is the true power of the myth. It provides the foundational, unquestioned legitimacy for trillions of dollars of modern real estate. The twenty four dollars and the beads make the origin seem quaint, harmless, and peaceful, effectively masking the profound, devastating dispossession of indigenous land that actually occurred over the following decades, which gives your narrative the perfect bridge into the next phase of the story. Up to this point, you've debunked the price, you've completely debunked the beads, and you've explained the psychology behind the lie, right? But any transaction, any contract requires two sides. Who is on the other side of the table, who actually sold the island? And here we hit another massive, impenetrable wall of silence in the primary sources because the records were pulped. We simply do not know who sold Manhattan. The specific identity, the tribal affiliation, the names of the Native American leaders who interacted with the Dutch in sixteen twenty six are completely unknown to history. Now, I know someone watching your video is going to jump into the comments and say, wait, it was the Canarsie. I read that the Canarsie tribe lived in Brooklyn, and they traveled over to Manhattan and scammed the Dutch by selling land they didn't even own. Yeah, that's a classic. That is probably the single most repeated piece of New York historical trivia. It is a very popular piece of trivia, and it is also a complete fabrication. Of course it is. At this point, I shouldn't even be surprised. Let's unpack the Canarsie scam myth. Where did that come from? The historian Stephen Mcerlean actually tracked this specific stubborn claim down to its origin. He combed through the massive volumes of colonial archives, looking for any contemporary mention of the Canarsie, tricking the Dutch in sixteen twenty six. And what did he find? He found absolutely nothing. What he did find was that this clever scam story almost certainly originated in a nineteen fifty nine magazine article written by a humorist named Nathaniel Benchley, nineteen fifty nine that's the year the microchip was invented. People act like the Canarsie scam is an ancient, documented historical fact, and it was literally invented by a magazine writer trying to be funny during the Eisenhower administration. It perfectly illustrates how willing we are to accept stories that flatter our modern sensibilities. The idea of the savvy, street smart locals pulling a fast one on the naive European colonizers is a very fun, cynical reversal of the usual tragic narrative. So it's stuck in the public consciousness. But it has absolutely zero basis in the sixteen twenty six primary sources. So if it wasn't the Canarsie pulling a real estate scam from across the river, who was actually living on Manhattan at the time? Do we have any primary source evidence that the indigenous population, we do have evidence of who lived there very shortly after the transaction. In a letter written in sixteen twenty eight, a man named Isaac de Rosier, who was the chief commercial agent and secretary of the province, mentions that the island was inhabited by a group of Indians he called the Manhattan okay. He estimated they were about two hundred to three hundred strong men and women living under different chiefs in various settlements across the island. Okay, so there was a distinct local population living right there, but we just have zero proof that they were the specific individuals who stood across from the Dutch and agreed to the sixty guilders. Exactly. We know people were there, but the records don't name the individuals their tribal affiliation or their specific leaders who engaged in the negotiation. But your video can't just throw its hands up and say, well, we don't know. You have to explain why the transaction was so fundamentally fraught, even if we knew exactly who was standing there. That's vital. And

this comes down to explaining the most fundamental, catastrophic clash of civilizations, the very concept of real estate itself. This is a crucial educational moment for your audience. You have to explain the stark difference between European and Indigenous property laws. The Dutch, coming from a highly developed, land scarce European society, were operating under a legal concept called fee. Simple. Fee. Simple. Okay, this is the concept of absolute exclusive private property. When you buy land under fee simple, you own it permanently, you own it exclusively, and you have the legal right to violently expel anyone else from it. That's the way we all think of buying a house today. I hand you the money, I get the keys and you have to pack your bags and leave forever. But the Native Americans in the region, the Lenape, operated under a completely different, highly complex system of usufruct rights. These were essentially shared use agreements. Interesting. Land was not a static, inert commodity to be owned exclusively forever by a single person. It was a living environment. You could grant a neighboring group the right to hunt on a specific tract of land, or the right to farm a specific plot near a river, or the right to establish a temporary seasonal camp. Right. But granting that specific use right didn't extinguish your own inherent right to continue using the land simultaneously. Here is an analogy that might work really well to make this abstract legal concept instantly relatable for your viewers. Imagine I am the Dutch colonists and you are the Lenape. We sit down and make a deal. I think I'm buying your house outright. Okay. I hand you a bunch of valuable goods. I sign a paper and I expect you to move out so I can change the locks. Yeah, but you think I'm just paying for a streaming subscription? Yes. You think I'm paying for the right to occasionally come over and hang out in your living room and watch movies with you? That captures the disconnect perfectly. You are both participating in the exact same exchange of goods, perhaps even signing the same physical piece of paper. But you are conceptualizing two entirely different, mutually exclusive realities of what that agreement means. But let me play devil's advocate here. How do we know the Dutch were aggressively imposing fee? Simple. If the actual Manhattan deed is missing. Maybe the Dutch understood it was just a shared use agreement. We know they intended fee. Simple, because we have proxy sources. Since the sixteen twenty six deed is lost to the pulp mill, historians look at the next best thing, which are the surviving deeds from the exact same colony just a few years later? Okay. Like what? For example, look at the sixteen thirty De for the purchase of Staten Island, which did survive the eighteen twenty one purge. Let me look at the text of that Staten Island proxy deed. Let's see. Okay. This is incredibly dense. It names the specific Native American settlers, and then it uses this incredibly heavy, absolute Dutch legal terminology. Read it out loud. It says the seller's transfer, cede, convey and deliver the land with its forest dependencies and dependencies, giving him actual and real possession thereof, as well as complete and irrevocable authority and special power. Listen to those words complete an irrevocable authority that is not the language of a friendly, shared use agreement. That is the language of total permanent ownership. They were drafting these documents to make sure they held up in a European court in Amsterdam, actively imposing Western legal structures onto indigenous diplomatic negotiations. But how did the Native Americans react when they realize the Dutch weren't just paying for a streaming subscription, but were actually trying to change the locks on the house. How did that play out on the ground? We have a brilliant primary source that illustrates this exact clash perfectly. It's not from Manhattan itself, but it's from the same colony dealing with the exact same Dutch West India Company

protocols. We need to look at the sixteen forty eight Van Slooten case in the Arnhem archives. Walk us through what happened in that case. Brandt Van Slyke was an agent for a wealthy Dutch patroon tasked with buying large tracts of land from the Mohawks and Mohicans further up the Hudson River near present day Albany. Years later, he ended up suing his employers for back pay and expenses. Classic, right? And in those court records, he meticulously detailed what buying land from the Native Americans actually entailed. And it completely shatters the myth of a simple retail transaction. It wasn't just a quick closing at a title company where everyone signs a paper and leaves. Not at all. Vince Lipton horse, testified that to secure a land agreement, he had to host dozens of Native American leaders and their retinues, sometimes up to fifty people at a time, for days or even weeks before any agreement was reached. While weeks of hosting he had to feed them, provide continuous supplies of beer and trade goods, and engage in elaborate, ongoing diplomacy, the exchange of goods wasn't a one time payment for a deed. It was the initiation of a continuous relationship of tribute, alliance and shared space. That is such a vital point to make in your video. The American myth tells us it was a one and done swap. Twenty four dollars. Here's the island. See you later. Pleasure doing business. Exactly. But the reality was a continuous, exhausting, deeply misunderstood negotiation of coexistence that required constant maintenance. And we see undeniable evidence of this coexistence continuing right on Manhattan itself. Remember that sixteen twenty eight letter from Isaac de Rosier? He wrote it two full years after the supposed sale of the island. And when he describes the Native Americans on Manhattan, he uses the present tense. He explicitly states that the Indians are inhabiting the island. They hadn't packed up and left. Exactly. They didn't go anywhere because in their minds, they hadn't sold their right to exist there. They had simply agreed to let the Dutch build a trading post and share the space. They were still hanging out in the living room. The purchase didn't magically clear the island for European development. It initiated a very complex, deeply fraught and often tense period of shared habitation that would eventually break down into horrific violence in the decades to come. Which brings us to the final, necessary phase of your narrative structure. You've walked your viewers through the primary sources, the lost archives, the nineteenth century fabrications, and the reality of the cultural clash. Now you need to bring the history all the way to the present day. Yeah. How do we look at this sixteen twenty six event right now, as we rapidly approach the four hundredth anniversary of the city in twenty twenty six? right? This is how you show your audience why any of this four hundred year old history still matters, because the framing of this event isn't static. It is actively shifting, evolving, and being debated right now as we speak. If you look at the primary materials coming out of the official NY four hundred organization, which is the central group tasked with planning the twenty twenty six commemorations for New York, they are fundamentally changing the vocabulary of the city's origins in their official literature. They no longer refer to the event as the purchase of Manhattan. That is a massive shift. What are they calling it instead? They explicitly refer to it as the negotiation with the Lenape people, the power of changing that one single word by shifting from purchase to negotiation. They are completely shattering the nineteenth century fee. Simple twenty four dollars myth. The word negotiation acknowledges the complexity, the lack of finality, and the ongoing relationship we just spent so much time talking about. Furthermore, the political establishment is also shifting its stance. Mayor Eric Adams has officially proclaimed November twentieth as Lanark Heritage Day in New York City, and major

cultural institutions are following suit. The Museum of the City of New York is launching a massive, highly publicized exhibit in September twenty twenty six. And what is the focus of that exhibit? It is titled halloumi A Katakana. Lenape. Legacies and futures. Notice the word futures. It's not just looking back at sixteen twenty six as a closed chapter. It is actively highlighting the ongoing survival, presence and sovereignty of the Lenape people today that provides the absolute perfect visual contrast. For the finale of your video, you need to show your viewers the nineteen oh nine Hudson-fulton Parade float. That giant, ridiculous papier maché caricature with the Dutchman handing out beads to defeated looking natives. Yes. And then you contrast that directly side by side with the twenty twenty six museum exhibit focusing on Lenape futures and ongoing sovereignty. Because ultimately, this is the core thesis of your video project. Every century uses the events of sixteen twenty six as a mirror to reflect its own immediate values, political needs, and cultural anxieties. Let's break down exactly how that works century by century, so our creator can clearly summarize it for their audience. So in the seventeenth century, the Dutch used the transaction and recorded it in dry corporate letters like Peter Shotguns to prove to their aggressive European rivals, specifically the English, that they had a legal, documented, heavily capitalized right to occupy the territory. Right. For them, it was purely about international geopolitics and corporate territory. Then we moved to the nineteenth century. The newly wealthy New York elites used the memory of the transaction and actively invented the twenty four dollars and the beads to create a sanitized, morally justifiable, peaceful origin myth because for them, it was about easing their capitalist conscience and legitimizing their massive real estate wealth. Exactly. And now, in the twenty first century, as we approach twenty twenty six, we're using the memory of that exact same event to acknowledge indigenous sovereignty. To actively deconstruct the violent myths of colonization, and to highlight the ongoing presence of the Lenape people, we're using the past to try and correct the moral ledger of the present. Yes. So the overarching message you need to leave your viewers with is this the objective truth of the exact mechanical transaction in sixteen twenty six almost matters less than how we have continuously manipulated, adapted, and weaponized the memory of that transaction to serve whoever is holding the pen at the time. The physical void left by the destroyed archives in eighteen twenty one was simply filled by the psychological needs of the present over and over again, generation after generation. Perfectly said. All right, let's take a breath and clearly summarize this narrative architecture. So you, our listener, have a solid blueprint for your video. First, you start with the hook and the shotgun letter. You show that the only primary source is a mundane cargo manifest, emphasizing the sixty guilders and the stark reality of the seven thousand two hundred and forty six beaver pelts. Second, you introduce the void. You explain the tragedy of eighteen twenty one, where the Dutch government literally pulped the records, leaving a massive blank canvas for historians. Third, you trace the active invention of the myth. You show your audience exactly how E.B. O'Callaghan calculated the twenty four dollars eighteen forty four, and how William Ranney painted the beads in eighteen fifty three, permanently cementing a sanitized origin story. Fourth, you explore the legal clash over real estate. You debunk the Canarsie scam myth. You use proxy documents like the Staten Island deed to explain European fee. Simple. And you use the Van Schlechten Haus case to explain indigenous shared use agreements. And finally, you end with the twenty twenty six reframing. You contrast the historical caricatures of the past with the modern acknowledgment of Lenape negotiation and ongoing survival. It is

a truly compelling structure. It relies entirely on the surviving primary sources, but it tells a much larger, much more resonant story about how history itself is manufactured. But before we wrap up this deep dive, we want to leave you with a final, provocative thought, something you can use as a post-credit scene in your video, or just a philosophical question to mull over as you sit down to write your script. We spent a lot of time talking about the scrap paper tragedy of eighteen twenty one, the physical destruction of the archives. But what if those bureaucrats had made a different choice? What if that destruction had never happened? Yeah, imagine an alternate timeline. What if John Romeyn Brodhead had arrived in The Hague in eighteen thirty nine, walked into the archives, and the archivist had said, ah, yes, the Manhattan deed. We've kept it perfectly safe right this way. And they pulled out a perfectly preserved, multi-page parchment contract with intact wax seals. Imagine we actually possess that document. Imagine it contained the specific, undeniable names of the Native American leaders. Imagine it contained the exact itemized list of trade goods exchanged every iron kettle, every all, every yard of duffel cloth. Wow. And imagine it contained the exact nuance translated terms of the shared use agreement the Lenape thought they were making. If we had that undeniable primary source sitting under glass in a museum in New York right now, would the history of the city have been fundamentally different? Would those nineteenth century elites have been forced by the sheer weight of historical evidence to acknowledge the complexity of the indigenous claims or. And I think this is the darker, much more profound question for your viewers to consider is the myth of the twenty four dollars and the beads so culturally potent, so desperately necessary to the American narrative of inevitable conquest and triumphant capitalism that we would have just ignored the real document anyway. Would we have looked at the real complicated deed, locked it away in a dark vault, and consciously chosen to print the legend? Because sometimes, when the truth is a muddy, complicated, exhausting landscape of continuous negotiation and moral ambiguity, we prefer the comfort of a clean, simple, binary myth, even if we have to forge it ourselves.